In Praeclara Summorum

Benedict XV · 1921-04-30 · English

Dante's Sixth Centenary The Holy Father's Encyclical

O Our beloved sons the professors and students of all the Catholic institutions for instruction in litera-

ture and higher culture on the sixth centenary of the death of Dante Alighieri.

Benepict XV, Pope.

Beloved sons, Health and the Apostolic Benediction. Amongst the many famous geniuses who are glories of the Catholic Faith, and who, besides leaving in other fields of knowledge, have left especially in literature and art immortal fruit of their ability, deserving greatly of religion and civilization, a special position has been at- tained by. Dante Alighieri, the sixth centenary of whose death will soon be celebrated. But perhaps his singular greatness has never been set forth in such strong light as today, when not only is Italy, which is justly proud of having been his' birthplace, exerting herself to honor his memory, but all civilized nations through fitting com- mittees of the learned are preparing to celebrate his memory in order that this exalted figure, the pride and orna- ment of humanity, may be honored by the whole world. Now, in this wonderful chorus of all good men it is fit- ting that Our voice should not be wanting but that We should in a certain sense take the lead_ inasmuch as, first and foremost, the Church has a parental right to call Alighieri her own. As, then, at the beginning of Our

'Pontificate, in a letter addressed to the Archbishop of

Ravenna, We promoted the restoration of the church where the ashes of the poet repose, so now, at the begin- ning of the centennial festivities, it has seemed right to address you all, beloved sons, who cultivate letters under the maternal vigilance of the Church, in order to show more clearly the intimate union of Dante with this Chair of Peter and how the praise bestowed on such an exalted name necessarily redounds in no small measure to the honor of the Catholic Church.

A CatHotic CELEBRATION And, first of all, since the divine poet during his entire life professed the Catholic religion in an exemplary man- ner, it can be regarded as in harmony with his wishes that this solemn commemoration should take place, as it will, under the auspices of religion and that, if it is com- pleted at St. Francis', Ravenna, its beginning is at Flor- ence, in his beautiful Church of St. John, to which his thoughts were turned with intense longing in the later years of his life when he was an exile, desiring to be crowned there as a poet at his baptismal font. Born in an age which received as an inheritance from the past the splendid fruits of doctrine and philosophical and theological speculation, and transmitted them to future ages with the stamp of the rigorous Scholastic method, Dante amidst the various currents of thought which were then diffused amongst the learned became a disciple of that prince of the schools, whose teaching was so clear owing to the angelic character of his intellect, St. Thomas Aquinas, and from him derived almost all his philosoph- ical and theological science; though he did not neglect any branch of human knowledge and drank largely at the fountains of the Holy Scripture and the Fathers. Having thus become acquainted with almost all the knowledge that could be attained in his day and having been specially nourished with Christian wisdom, when he prepared to write it was from the sphere of religion that he undertook to treat a subject which was immense and of the greatest importance. Wherefore if the won- derful vastness and force of his genius is to be admired, we must also recognize the powerful impulse of inspira- tion which he derived from Divine Faith and which enabled him to embellish his immortal poem with the multi= form lights of revealed truths no less than with all the splendor of art. In fact, his "Commedia," which has deservedly received the title of "Divine," even in the different symbolical stories and in the records of the life of men on earth aims at nothing: else than to glorify the justice and providence of God, who governs the world in time and in eternity and punishes or rewards the actions of individuals and of human society.

Therefore, in accordance with Divine Revelation shine forth in this poem the majesty of the one Triune God, the Redemption of the human race effected by the Word of , God made Man, the great mercy and goodness of Mary, Virgin and Mother, Queen of Heaven, and finally the heavenly happiness of the Saints, the Angels and men, to which indeed in the opposite region, in hell, are set the punishments ordained for the guilty; between both being fixed the seat of souls destined, after expiration, to heavenly bliss. It is truly marvelous how wisely these and other

Catholic dogmas are interwoven in the whole of the work. And, if the progress of astronomical sci- ence showed that there was no basis for this conception of the world and that the spheres supposed by the ancients do not exist, seeing that the nature, number, and course of the stars and the planets are altogether different from what they thought them to be, the fundamental principle was not the less true that the universe, whatever be the order that sustains. it in its parts, is governed by the will —by which it was established—of Almighty God, who moves and rules all things and whose glory shines more in one part and less in another, and that this earth which we inhabit, although it be not the center of the universe, as was believed at one time, was the abode of our first parents and therefore the witness of their unhappy fall anel of man's redemption by the death of our Lord Jesus Christ.

A Treasury OF RELIicious TRUTHS

Wherefore the divine poet explained the triple life of the souls that he had arranged in his mind, so that in de- claring before the last judgment the damnation of the wicked, the purgation of the good spirits, and the eternal happiness of the blessed, he appears to seek clear: light in his close knowledge of the Faith.

Now, amongst the truths prominently brought out by Alighieri in his threefold poem, and also in his other works, we believe that these especially may prove in- structive to people of the present time. That Christians owe supreme reverence to the Holy Scriptures and oaght to receive with perfect docility what they contain he loudly proclaims when he says that though there are many

copyists of the Divine Word, one alone is Dictator: God who has deigned to indicate to us His will through the pens of many (Mon. iii, 4), a splendid expression of a great truth. So also, when he states that the Old and the New Testament, which are prescribed for eternity, as the Prophet says, contain spiritual teachings which transcend human reason, imparted by the Holy Spirit, who, through the Prophets and the sacred writers, through Jesus Christ, co-eternal Son of God, and His disciples, revealed the supernatural truth necessary for us (Mon. iti, 3, 16). Most correctly, therefore, does he say concerning the future life, "We have the certainty of it in the most truthful doctrine of Christ, which is the way, the truth and the light; the way, because through it, without obstruction we proceed to the happiness of immortality; the truth, because it is free from all error; the light, because it illumines us in the darkness of worldly ignorance (Conv. ii, 9). Nor does he show less reverence for those ven- erable chief Councils at which none of the Faithful doubts that Christ was present; and in great esteem with him were also the writings of the Doctors, St. Augustine and the others, as to whom he says that anyone who doubts that they were aided by the Holy Spirit has never seen their fruits, or, if he has seen them, has never tasted them (Mon. iii, 3).
DANTE AND THE CHURCH's AUTHORITY ad

Astonishing is the high opinion Alighieri held of the authority of the Catholic Church and the power of the Roman Pontiff as that on which is based every law and institution of the Church itself. Wherefore this ener- getic admonition to Christians: "You have the Old and the New Testament and the Pastor of the Church who guides you: this is sufficient for your salvation." He felt the evils from which the Church suffered as if they were his own, and, deploring and execrating every rebel- lion against the supreme head, he thus wrote to the Italian Cardinals during the stay of the Popes at Avignon:

We, then, who confess the same Father and Son, the same God and Man, and the same Mother and Virgin; we, for whom and for whose salvation was said to him who out of love was interrogated three times: "Peter, feed the sheep of My holy fold"; we. of Rome (of that Rome for which, after the pomp

of so many triumphs, Christ in word and work confirmed the empire of the world, and which Peter, and Paul, the Apostle of the Gentiles, consecrated as the Apostolic See with their own blood), are constrained with Jeremiah, lamenting not for the future, but for the present, to grieve for as widowed and deserted; we are oppressed by sorrow at seeing her thus suffering and also at seeing the lamentable plague of heresy (Epist. viii).

For him the Roman Church is the pious: mother or Spouse of the Crucified; and to Peter, infallible judge of revealed truth, is due perfect submission in matters of faith and morals. Hence though it was his opinion that the dignity of the Emperor proceeded immediately from God, still he asserts that this truth is not to be so strictly understood that the Roman prince is subject in nothing to the Roman Pontiff; since this mortal happiness is in 'some manner ordained for immortal happiness (Mon. iii, 16). In truth an excellent and wise principle, which, if it were observed, as it should be today, would bring to States the rich fruit of civil prosperity. ,

But it -will be said that he attacked the Sovereign Pon- tiffs of his time so bitterly and contumeliously. Yes, but these were Popes who disagreed with them in politics and who, he believed, belonged to the party that had banished him from his country. But we must extend pardon to a man so tossed about by fortune's

terrible waves, if with a mind full of irritation he sometimes bursts into invectives which seem without measure; all the more be- cause, to inflame his anger, there were not wanting evil reports, propagated, as is customary, by political adver- saries, always inclined to put a bad interpretation on every- thing. Moreover, such is the weakness of mortals that even religious hearts must become stained with the grime of the world's dust; and who will deny that there were at- that time amongst the clergy things to be reproved at which a soul so devoted to the Church as that of Dante must have been quite disgusted, and we know that men distinguished for eminent sanctity then emphat- ically re- proved them. But however vehemently he rightly or rashly attacked ecclesiastical persons, not a whit less, however, was the respect which he felt due to the Church and the feverence for the supreme keys; wherefore in politics he knew how to defend his own opinion with "that homage which a pious son should employ towards his

own father—pious towards his mother, pious to- wards Christ, pious towards the Church, pious to- wards the Pastor, pious towards all who profess the Christian religion for the protection of truth." (Mon. iti, 3).

Aw Armory oF CaTHoLic Doctrine

Accordingly, having based the whole structure of his poem or such solid religious principles, it is not sur- prising that it should be found a treasure of Catholic doctrine, that, not only the juice of Christian philos- ophy and the- ology but also a compendium of the Divine laws which should regulate the order and ad- ministration of States; for Alighieri was not the man to maintain that, in order to enlarge one's country or to gratify rulers, justice and the laws of God could be neglected by the State, in the, observance of which he well knew the welfare of the State chiefly depended.

Wonderful, then, is the intellectual enjoyment which the study of this great poet affords; and not less is the profit which the studious derive from him, perfecting their artistic taste and inflaming their zeal for virtue; only let those who approach him be free from prejudices and open to the influence of truth. It may also be said that, whilst the number of great Catholic poets who com- bine the useful with the delectable are not few, this is singular in Dante that, fascinating the reader with the marvelous variety of his images, the beauty of the colors, and the grandeur of the words anal sentences, he entices him to the love of Christian wisdom ; and let no one forget that hé openly confessed that he had composed his poem to provide "vital nourishment" for all. As a matter of fact we know that some, even recently, far from Christ, but not opposed to Him, studying the "Divina Commedia" with love, by Divine grace first commenced to admire the truth of the Catholic Faith and finished by casting them- selves enthusiastically into the arms of the Church.

What we have said so far suffices to prove how op- portune it is that on the occasion of this world- centenary each one should intensify his zeal for the preservation of the Faith, which revealed itself so luminously, if ever in others, certainly in: Alighieri as a promoter of culture and art, since in him not only is the loftiness of his genius

admired, but also the grandeur of the theme that our holy religion offered him as a subject for song. If the acumen of his great genius brought him near, after long medita- tion and study, to the classical masterpieces of the an- cients, it was still more vig- orously tempered, as We have already said, by the writings of the Doctors and Fathers, which gave him a wing to lift himself in the horizon far above those who are enclosed in the brief ambit of nature. Where- fore, although separated from us by an interval of centuries, he still betrays the freshness of a poet of our age; and certainly he is much more modern than certain ~ recent poets; exhumers of that paganism which was banished forever by Christ triumphant on the Cross. Alighieri breathes the same piety as we do, the same sentiments, the same faith, and is clothed in the same garment, come to us from Heaven, "the truth by which we are lifted so high."

Tue Poet oF CHRISTIAN IDEALS

This is his chief praise, to be a Christian poet: that is to say, to have sung in Divine accents those Christian ideals which he passionately admired in all the vigor of their beauty, being profoundly attached to them and living in them. And those who venture to deny such merit to Dante and reduce all the religious substructure of the "Divina Commedia' to a vague ideology that has no foundation of truth, overlook in Dante what is charac- teristic and the foundation of all his other merits.

If, then, Dante owed such a large share of his fame and grandeur to the Catholic Faith, this single example, not to mention others, is enough to prove how false it is to say that the offering of the homage of the mind and heart to God clips the wings of genius, whilst, on the contrary, genius is spurred and exalted by it; and how wretchedly they provide for the progress of culture and civilization who wish to banish every idea of religion from public instruction. Very deplorable in truth is the system adopted today of educating studious youth in such a way as if God did not exist and without the slightest allusion to the

supernatural, for if in some places the “sacred poem” is not kept out of the school and is even numbered amongst the books that ought to be most earnestly studied,

it cannot for the most part supply the young with that “vital nourishment” which it is destined to produce inas- much as, owing to disciplinary directions, it is not, as it should be, fittingly disposed with regard to the truths of the Faith. God grant that this celebration may have the result that wherever literary studies are cultivated Dante may be held in due honor and may become himself the teacher of Christian doctrine, he who professed that his poem had no other object than to lift up mortals from the state of misery, that is, from sin and to lead them to the * state of happiness, that is, of Divine grace. And you, be- loved sons, who are called to follow the paths of literature under the guidance of the Church, love and hold dear the poet whom We do not hesitate to proclaim the most eloquent singer of Christian wisdom. The more you study him, the higher will be your culture, irradiated by the splendors of truth, and the stronger and more spon- taneous will be your homage to the Catholic Faith.

As a pledge of heavenly favors, and in testimony of Our paternal benevolence, We heartily grant to you all, beloved sons, the Apostolic Benediction.

‘ Benepict XV, Pope.

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